

An Autistic Student in Your Sport / Society

For university sport, gym & society coaches and leaders — supporting an autistic student (roughly ages 18–25).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a student's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." University clubs can be a genuine refuge — structure, shared interest, belonging — for a student navigating a chaotic new life. But the social, sensory and initiation demands of club life (initiations, loud socials, last-minute changes) can also push a depleted student into **burnout**. Lean into the structure and the interest, lower the social/sensory load, and your club becomes the steady anchor many autistic students need.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Brilliant and reliable at training; skips the social	The sport fits; the social doesn't — high-channel load, not aloofness
Burns out mid-term; stops coming	Cumulative university load tipping into burnout
Intense focus on technique, kit or a single role	Monotropic strength — give them that role
Won't do initiations, loud socials or group chats	Sensory/social overload — offer low-pressure alternatives
Takes instructions literally; prefers written plans	Literal, single-channel communication

Try this

- **Make training predictable** — consistent time, place, plan; share the session plan in advance in writing.
- **Show, then say; one focus at a time**; use video or a whiteboard for tactics.
- **Offer low-sensory, low-pressure social options** alongside (not instead of) the sport; never make initiations mandatory.
- **Use the interest and strengths** — a defined role (kit, stats, setup) gives certainty and belonging.
- **Check in literally and privately** if a reliable regular stops coming; burnout needs reduced load, not a pep talk.

Avoid this

- Surprise socials, initiations, loud buses or last-minute fixture changes with no notice.
- Equating club commitment with attending every loud social event.
- Reading a withdrawal or a literal question as disengagement.

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout** (exhaustion, loss of skills, reduced tolerance) and signpost the **student wellbeing/disability service**. Keep membership flexible; a reduced or social-only role mid-term can keep a struggling student connected while they recover.

If the student is a woman

Women and marginalised-gender students mask intensely and are often late-identified; a “sociable high-achiever” may be privately exhausted. Take reduced tolerance and withdrawal seriously.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 4, sports & coaching), the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.4) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Michaud & Harvey (2025, physical-activity scoping review); Dwyer (2025); Raymaker et al. (2020). Full citations are in the source drafts.